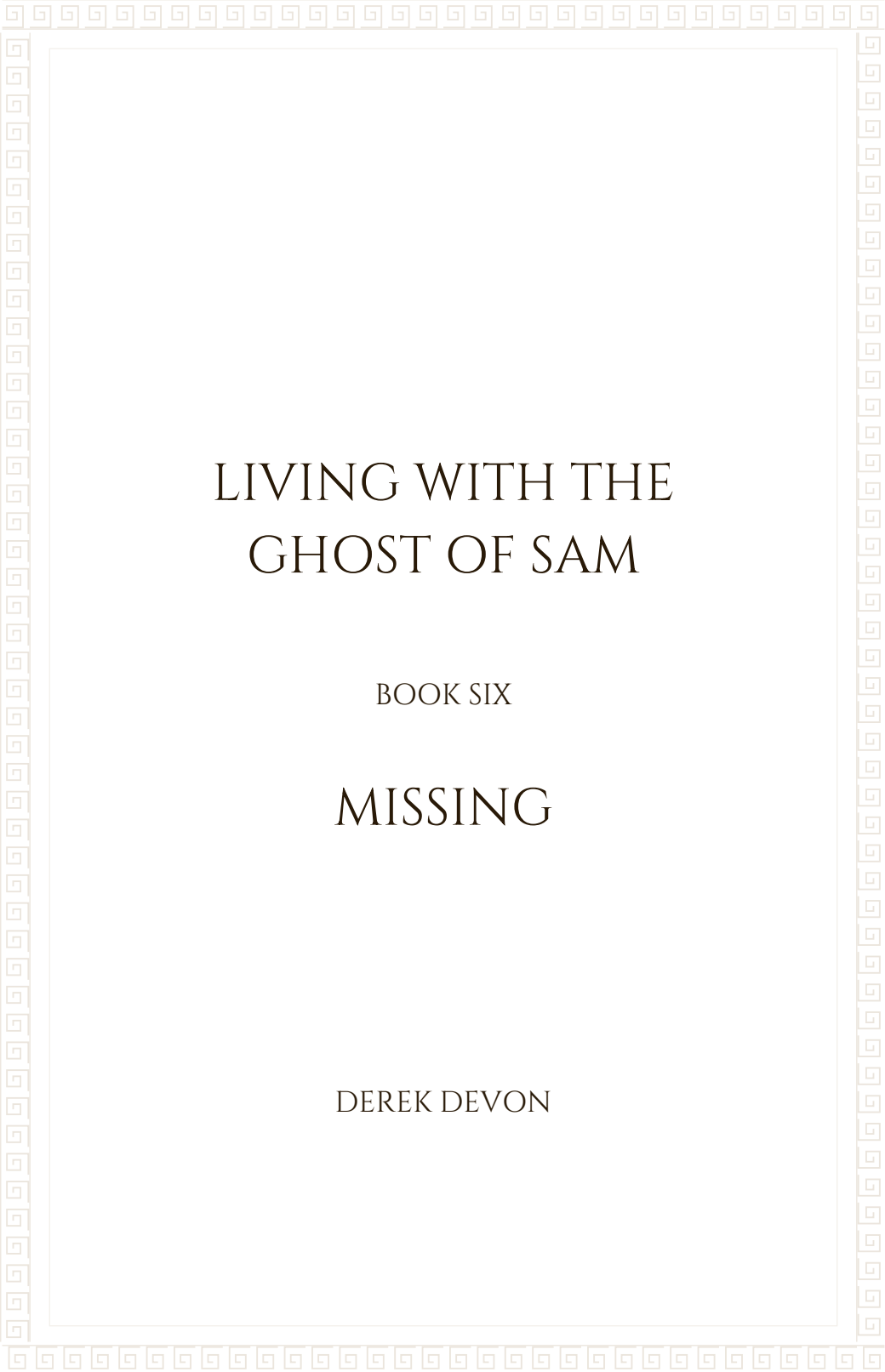




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK SIX

MISSING

DEREK DEVON

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To everyone who ever tried the thing they weren't qualified for —
who quit the safe job, wrote the first page, took the stage on open-mic
night with no act and less sense.

Comfort zones are just haunted houses where nothing interesting lives.

Step outside. The thunder is usually on your side.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two

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TEASER: OLD MOSES HAS EXPENSIVE TASTE

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline. Sometimes it's a banana peel. Sometimes it's a pie in the face. And sometimes — OH OH OHHHH — it's a lake that eats docks and a town where the real estate agent's reflection doesn't match her face. Stick around, folks. Somebody's about to go missing, and trust me, in this town, "missing" is a very flexible word.

There are lakes that invite you in, and there are lakes that merely tolerate you, and then there is Crescent Lake, which had always given the impression of a lake that was keeping a list.

The fog came off it in the pre-dawn dark like something being poured, dense and slow, swallowing the shoreline a few feet at a time. It was the hour when reasonable people were asleep, unreasonable people were getting home, and only two categories of soul were awake and outdoors: fishermen, and things that eat fishermen. Through the mist, an old wooden dock extended into the black water like a finger testing the temperature of something it should have left alone.

The weathered planks creaked under the weight of two men who, by any reasonable actuarial standard, had no business being out here at this hour. Earl — seventy-something, owner of the gas station and Harrison's Outdoor Supply, and the closest thing

Oceanview had to an oral historian — was unpacking supplies from a tackle box that looked like it had survived two wars and lost a third. Pete, a diner regular in his sixties who had made the mistake of saying yes to Earl one too many times, struggled with a spool of fishing line heavy enough to tow a boat.

A flickering lantern threw uncertain light across their faces, the kind of light that made everything look like the opening five minutes of a movie where things do not go well for the men on the dock. Neither of them had ever seen that movie, of course. They had seen a different movie, in 1975, at a drive-in two counties over, and it was about to become extremely relevant.

"You sure about this spot, Earl?" Pete asked, stringing the line.

"Been catching Old Moses's granddaddy here since before you could walk," Earl said. "Biggest catfish you ever saw."

Pete pulled a hook from the tackle box and held it up to the lantern. It was massive — less "catfish" and more "we're gonna need a bigger boat." Meanwhile Earl unwrapped a butcher-paper package containing a cut of meat that bore a suspicious resemblance to prime rib. Specifically, to the prime rib from Betty's special menu at The Last Laugh Diner.

"Ain't that from Betty's special menu?" Pete asked.

Earl grinned. "She won't miss it. Besides, Old Moses has expensive taste."

They worked the meat onto the hook with the solemnity of men performing a ritual older than either of them, which, in a sense, it was. Earl lashed the line to a sturdy dock post with knots his grandfather had taught him — the same grandfather who had worked maintenance up at the asylum and who, come to think of it, had also refused to fish this lake after dark. Pete watched with the nervous energy of a man who had seen this exact scene in a theater in 1975 and remembered how it ended.

"Hand me that lantern, Pete. Let's see what we're doing here."

Earl tossed the baited hook far out into the dark water. The splash echoed across the lake and died, and the fog swallowed the ripples.

"Now what?" Pete asked.

"Now we wait. And whatever you do, don't—"

The line went taut.

Not fishing-taut. Not even big-catfish-taut. The dock post *groaned*, a deep wooden complaint that traveled up through the planks and into the soles of Pete's boots.

"Sweet Jesus..." Earl breathed.

The post splintered. Before Pete could so much as select a curse word, the entire section of dock beneath him tore away with a thunderous crack, and Pete found himself tumbling onto a broken wooden platform that was now — impossibly, undeniably — *moving across the lake*.

"Earl! Do something!"

Earl watched helplessly from the remaining dock. "Didn't think he'd be that hungry!" he called out, followed by a chuckle that suggested his helplessness was, at minimum, comfortable.

The dock section picked up speed. Pete lost his grip and hit the water with a splash that scattered the fog. He surfaced, sputtering, and began swimming for shore with a form that no coach would endorse but which covered water at a genuinely impressive rate.

Earl, meanwhile, had settled into his lawn chair and opened a beer. "Better hurry back, Pete, before Old Moses wants you for dinner as well!"

What followed was, beat for beat, the most famous swimming scene in cinema history: Pete thrashing through dark water,

something seeming to churn in his wake, the black surface of the lake giving away nothing. What Pete could not see — and what would have improved his morning considerably — was that the thing behind him was headed the *opposite* direction. The broken dock section was being pulled away across the lake, erratic and fast, like a chew toy in the mouth of something that hadn't decided whether to play with it or swallow it.

"Better hurry, Pete, he's right behind you!" Earl offered, unhelpfully.

Pete reached the shore and rolled onto his back, chest heaving, one shoe missing, dignity gone the way of the dock.

Earl smiled down at him and extended a can. "Pete... beer?"

Out on the lake, the dock section was still moving, jerking left, then right, dragged through the fog by its invisible engine. Then it crashed into something solid. The sound rolled across the water — not the sound of wood hitting rock. The sound of wood hitting something that *noticed*.

Pete sat up, dripping, took the beer, and drank about half of it. His hands were shaking just enough to put a small tremolo on the can.

"Did you hear that, Earl?"

The fog didn't answer. Neither did Earl. He just sat there in his lawn chair with his beer, watching the mist where the dock had gone, wearing the expression of a man updating a mental ledger he had been keeping for a very long time.

Somewhere out in the gray, the water settled. It did not settle all the way.



CHAPTER ONE

SONNY BOY AND THE SUIT

Dawn found a sports car parked on the shoulder of a road that sports cars were never designed to meet. Inside, Chad Wellington III stared at his phone, where a small pulsing dot on a map sat directly beside the blue smear of Crescent Lake.

Marina's AirTag. Beside a lake. In the middle of nowhere.

Chad had been awake for twenty-six hours, and he had spent most of them negotiating with that dot — willing it to move, to blink into a hotel parking lot, a gas station, anywhere with a roof and a receipt. The dot had not moved since yesterday. Dots that don't move beside lakes are a genre of information the mind accepts only in installments.

His expression was grim as he put the car in gear.



Morning came to Ravencrest Mansion the way it always did — reluctantly, and with an air of having seen too much the night before.

In the study, Derek Kinison sat at his desk surrounded by an array of new computer monitors, their glow clashing gorgeously with the room's Victorian bones: dark wood paneling, ornate moldings, ancient leather-bound books that predated the concept of a software update. On the main screen, Charles Weber occupied a video window like a man who had personally negotiated the terms of his own pixel count. Behind him, his sleek corporate office: modern art on pristine white walls, San Francisco's skyline gleaming through floor-to-ceiling glass. The two rooms could not have been

more different if they'd been on different planets. Arguably, they were.

"Charles, I said two minutes ago that we need to keep the presentation simple for Jacobson's team," Derek said.

Charles adjusted himself in his ergonomic chair, a maneuver he performed the way other men cleared their throats. "OK, simple I get, but if we don't add more of your AI personality algorithm, it's just an old pig with fresh lipstick, Sonny boy."

Sonny boy.

In the mirror across the study — where Charles could not see and Derek was not looking — Sam appeared. And this time, Sam had committed to a bit. Because that was the thing about Sam, alive or otherwise: he never half-did a bit. He was done up in full Al Jolson blackface, the whole vaudeville catastrophe, down on one knee, one gloved hand pressed to his heart, the other flung wide to an audience of nobody.

"When there are grey skies," Sam crooned, launching into his best Jolson, "[AUTHOR INSERT — lyric, per script p.6] — Friends may try to screw you, don't let *Charles* try to screw you, I still have you, Sonny Boy — OH... OH... OHHHHHHHHH!"

Derek's head snapped toward the mirror. It showed a study, a desk, some monitors, and one confused former marketing executive. Nothing else.

He turned back to the screen. "Did you say something, Charles?"

"Yes, I said we need you to up the presentation game or we will lose this deal."

Derek sat there a moment, processing what he thought he'd heard — the voice, the melody, the unmistakable *OH OH OHHHHH* — and then did what he'd been doing more and more lately, which was file it in the mental drawer labeled *This House* and keep moving.

"OK, Charles, give me an hour and we will reconnect back here. I will see what I can pull together."

"I would head up there in a heartbeat, Derek, but I have too many commitments here, so you're on your own with this, genius. We need your top game for this presentation."

"OK, Charles, I hear you loud and clear. See you in an hour."

Derek clicked the mouse and Charles vanished mid-nod, which was the single best feature of video conferencing and possibly of modern technology as a whole. He leaned back in his chair and stared at the ceiling, which offered no notes on the presentation but at least didn't call him Sonny boy.

Fifteen years in corporate America had taught Derek to read a room, and lately he was getting an unwelcome reading off a room three thousand miles away. There was a new pitch in Charles's voice when the mansion's technology came up — a leaning-forward quality, the tone of a man who had stopped asking *what is this* and started asking *how do I get it*. Derek filed that, too. The drawer labeled *This House* was getting a neighbor, and the neighbor was labeled *Watch Charles*.

"Looks like you could use a break, Master Kinison."

Derek nearly levitated out of the chair. Smithers had materialized beside the desk with a silver tray, having made his entrance with the sound — the soft, precise *presence* of sound — that was somehow more startling than no sound at all.

"I brought you a little snack. I understand from Miss Nancy that when you're stressed, you like rice crispy squares with chocolate chips."

Derek stared at the tray. Then at Smithers. Then back at the tray. "How did... *when* did Nancy tell you that?" He sat up and turned to face the butler fully. "If that tray has a rice crispy square,

Smithers, you will have become my official Mansion favorite person."

Smithers smiled the smile of a man holding four aces and a fifth ace. "The mansion has ways of learning about its residents, Master Kinison. Much like how I know you prefer your coffee with one sugar, milk not cream, and that you secretly practice your presentations in the mirror when Miss Nancy isn't watching."

"You know, Smithers," Derek said, accepting a square with newfound appreciation, "sometimes I wonder if you and the mansion aren't one and the same."

Smithers extended the tray a diplomatic inch further, and Derek took two large squares and settled back into his chair, because when the universe offers, you take two.

The first bite was, objectively, the best rice crispy square Derek had eaten in his entire life, and Derek had eaten rice crispy squares under conditions of extreme professional duress on four continents. Marshmallow ratio: perfect. Chocolate chips: still faintly warm. He decided not to ask how a butler in a mansion at the end of a coastal road had achieved this, on the grounds that the answer would either be mundane and disappointing or accurate and alarming.

"Just a parting observation, Master Kinison," Smithers said, "but sometimes our gut instinct is the best measurer of what's right and what's not."

Derek turned the square over in his fingers, pondering Smithers' latest installment of quiet wisdom — the man dispensed it like a fortune cookie with a security clearance.

"I hear you, Smithers. But sometimes people just go bad. No warning, no 'Hey, I am changing on you.' They just go bad."

The butler inclined his head — not agreement, not disagreement, just the acknowledgment of a man who had watched

a great many people go a great many directions from inside this house — and withdrew as silently as he'd come.

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CHAPTER TWO

TRUST YOUR INSTINCTS, KID

One hour later, the study had been reset for round two. Derek adjusted his webcam while Charles's face filled one of the new monitors, Victorian elegance and modern technology continuing their uneasy détente around him.

"The Jacobson team isn't looking for simple, Derek," Charles said. "They want revolutionary. Show them what that mansion of yours can really do."

"I'm not sure that's—"

DING.

The dumbwaiter. Derek glanced at it with the nervous reflex of a man who had learned that in this house, appliances had opinions.

"One second, Charles."

He crossed the study and opened the little brass door. Inside sat a fresh cup of coffee — one sugar, milk not cream, naturally — and a handwritten note:

Trust your instincts, kid. But watch the suit. — S

Derek read it twice. The handwriting was loose and confident, the ink fresh, and the advice was — he noted with something between comfort and vertigo — a precise match for the conclusion he'd been circling all morning on his own. Which raised the eternal Ravenscrest question: was the house reading his mind, or was his mind finally catching up to the house?

"Everything alright?" Charles called from the monitor.

"Just Smithers with coffee," Derek said, which was at least one-third true.

As he carried the cup back to the desk, the study's mirror caught something in passing — a figure in a black beret, adjusting the angle of it with a performer's fussiness. But when Derek turned to look, only his own reflection remained, holding coffee, wearing the expression of a man who was starting to suspect the mirrors in this house had a green room.



Miles away, Chad's sports car navigated a rough logging road, its suspension registering formal complaints with every rut. He checked the phone mounted on the dash — the AirTag signal growing stronger, the pulsing dot swelling like a heartbeat.

The trees broke and the car rolled into a clearing that ended in sky. Chad got out and walked to the cliff's edge. Below, Crescent Lake spread gray and still, morning mist clinging to the water in ragged patches.

He checked the phone one last time. Then he looked down, and his expression changed.

Through the thinning fog: Marina's Range Rover. Half-submerged in the shallows, water lapping at its windows, patient and proprietary. And resting against it like driftwood — like the lake had arranged the tableau for maximum effect — a broken section of wooden dock.

"Oh god, Marina..." The words barely made it out of him.

He stood at the edge for a long moment, the wind coming up off the water and pushing at him gently, the way crowds push at the man nearest the platform edge. The Range Rover looked wrong down there — not crashed, not abandoned. *Placed*. Nose-in at the shallows, level and composed, like the lake had parked it. And the

broken dock leaning against it like a calling card.

Chad pulled out his phone, and for the first time in a very long career of knowing exactly who to call, he hesitated before dialing.



Back at the mansion, in the library, Nancy Hammond sat in her pajamas at the center of what could charitably be called a research explosion. Dusty books and folders covered every surface. An old map of the area sprawled across the table, its curling edges weighted down with leather-bound volumes that had been holding down other things since before the invention of the paperweight.

She pulled another book from a shelf — and two VHS tapes clattered to the floor, dislodged from wherever they'd been hiding for decades. She picked them up and read the labels.

GRAND OPENING.

GOVERNOR'S VISIT.

The handwriting on the labels was the same neat, clinical script she'd been staring at in Rhodes' documents all morning — a hand so orderly it made the words feel like specimens. Nancy turned the tapes over. No dates. No studio marks. Just those two labels, sitting in a private library, in a building that had been a psychiatric hospital, waiting forty-some years for a woman in pajamas to knock them loose.

In the library's mirror, a man in a bow tie appeared just long enough to adjust it. Milton Berle looked at her with the fond exasperation of a comic sizing up a crowd that didn't know it was a crowd yet.

"Kid, if you think those shows were something," Milton's reflection said, "wait'll you see what didn't make it to tape."

Nancy turned at the sound. The mirror showed books and dust and one woman in pajamas holding two VHS tapes.

"Is that you, Smithers?" she called. "Is that you, Larry?" A beat. "Is that you, *Sam*?" — and she laughed at the last one, because it was ridiculous, and because lately the ridiculous had a batting average that was making her nervous.

She got up and crossed to the mansion's retrofitted original intercom, a beautiful brass thing that had been given a discreet modern heart, and pressed the code for the study.

"Hey babe, you still in there?"

The speaker lay silent a moment. Then: "Ya, Charles is online with me. Working on the Jacobson stuff. How's it going with you?"

"Well, I may head into town in a while after I finish a little bit more reading. You want to come?"

"No, I have to finish with Charles, then I have to rehearse for tomorrow's BIG SHOE" — the Ed Sullivan impression again, shoulders audibly hunching even through the intercom. "Oh, but the biggest news today... Smithers made some rice crispy squares, and they are *unbelievable*."

"Well, don't go eating them all — save a few for me and Larry. I can't have you going porky on me up here."

"Not a chance. I will work it all off tonight."

"I thought you had to rehearse."

"I am already a master at that."

"Very cute. Get back to work..."

Nancy returned to the books and the map, slightly rejuvenated in the way that only a stupid flirty exchange with the love of your life can rejuvenate a person at eleven in the morning in a haunted library.

She spread the map flat and traced the shoreline of Crescent Lake with one finger, past the little inked rectangle of the old dock, up the ridge road, back to the heavy gothic X of the mansion itself. Whoever had drawn this map had annotated it in that same clinical hand — small notations at the church, the theater, the lake. She couldn't read most of them. The ones she could read, she read twice, and then decided the tape recorder was going on the shopping list.

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CHAPTER THREE

HELMET TEST 13

The state police cruiser pulled up beside Chad's car at the overlook, and two officers stepped out with the unhurried gait of men who had driven a long way and intended to bill for it.

"Mr. Wellington?" The older one — forties, with the weathered patience of a veteran cop — approached first.

"I found her car... down there," Chad said. "I didn't want to contaminate the scene."

Officer Jenkins took in the scene with a single practiced sweep — the sports car, the pressed slacks, the shoes that had never met a logging road before this morning and were visibly filing a grievance about it — and said, in a voice pitched low enough for plausible deniability, "And dirty those designer clothes."

His partner — thirties, with a notebook already open and the posture of a man who alphabetized his spice rack — was all business. "How exactly did you locate the vehicle, sir? This is in the middle of nowhere."

Chad hesitated, choosing his words with care, because the true answer — that he'd had someone secretly slip an Apple AirTag into Marina's purse months ago without her knowledge — was the kind of answer that turned a witness into a suspect before lunch.

"Marina had mentioned buying an AirTag a few weeks back. When she disappeared, I remembered she had linked it to my phone, and I decided to check my phone."

The officers exchanged a look — the second such look, and the looks were compounding interest. It was, as answers went,

technically plausible and spiritually unconvincing, the testimony of a man reading from a script he'd finished writing in the car. Jenkins keyed his radio.

"Dispatch, we're going to need Fire Rescue and additional units at Crescent Lake overlook. Possible recovery operation. I will text you directions."



In the mansion study, Derek fed a VHS tape marked *HELMET TEST #13* into an ancient player mounted on a rolling cart, which he'd angled beside the desk so that Charles, watching through the video call, had a clear view. Static filled the old TV screen.

"What exactly are we looking at?" Charles asked.

The static cleared — and revealed an audience. Rows of people in theater seats, every one of them wearing a strange metallic headset, wires trailing from the crowns like the roots of upside-down plants. Their faces were fixed on a stage. Their reactions were... wrong. Synchronized. A hundred people laughing at once, stopping at once, leaning forward at once, like a single organism practicing being a crowd.

On the stage, a figure stood at a control panel, adjusting settings with a technician's absorption. Derek recognized him from the photographs Nancy had unearthed: Jonathan Rhodes. As Rhodes's hands moved across the panel, the audience's expressions shifted again — in perfect unison.

It was the unison that got under Derek's skin. A crowd is a messy instrument; anyone who has ever bombed in a conference room knows a hundred faces never do the same thing at the same time. These did. A hundred smiles arriving on the same frame, like a single face wearing a hundred masks. Somewhere behind Derek's professional composure, a very old alarm — the kind installed in the

species long before PowerPoint — began quietly ringing.

"I'm... not sure," Derek said.

"What's on their heads?" Charles leaned into his camera. "Looks like wires are coming off of it."

"If I had to guess, it's some sort of metal cap."

"Maybe it was used to measure something in a person's head. After all, it was a mental hospital at one time."

"Or they were hosting a party for a bunch of people from Area 51," Derek said, deploying the joke like a smoke grenade and hoping the conversation would move under its cover.

DING.

The dumbwaiter again. Derek opened it and found a single handwritten page, its edge ragged — torn, unmistakably, from a journal. Rhodes' journal. The handwriting was neat, clinical, and completely at odds with what it said:

Test 13 successful. Consciousness synchronization achieved across all subjects. Ready for full implementation at next performance.

Outside, thunder rumbled across a sky that did not contain a single cloud.

Derek looked at the page. Then at the frozen image of the synchronized audience. Then at the window, where the innocent blue sky was still pretending it hadn't said anything.

Ready for full implementation at next performance. He turned the phrase over. Somewhere in the back of his mind, a date was trying to introduce itself to another date — Rhodes' last performance, Sam's last show, a hospital that closed and a club that opened and a town that died — and Derek, with the self-preservation of a man who had a corporate pitch in six hours, declined the introduction. For now.



CHAPTER FOUR

NO BODY IN THE VEHICLE

By late morning, the overlook had transformed. What had been a quiet clearing with one grieving man and one sports car was now a command center: Fire Rescue personnel checking climbing gear, state police stringing perimeter tape, radios crackling in overlapping bursts. A helicopter carved circles overhead, its rotor wash flattening the meadow grass in slow pulses.

The chopper set down at the clearing's edge, and out of it stepped a man in his fifties with the kind of commanding presence that made junior officers spontaneously remember paperwork they needed to do elsewhere. State Police Chief Patterson scanned the scene once, comprehensively, and his eyes landed on Chad.

"Chad Wellington," he said, crossing to him. "Long way from Los Angeles."

"Chief Patterson. Thanks for coming."

They moved together to the cliff edge, watching the rescue teams begin their descent, ropes paying out down the rock face toward the half-drowned Range Rover below. Patterson studied the scene the way he studied everything — once for what it was, once for what it wanted him to think it was.

"Want to tell me what really brought you here?" Patterson asked.

Before Chad could assemble an answer, a radio crackled at Patterson's shoulder:

"No body in the vehicle. Interior's sealed. Cell phone in a clip on the dash. Handbag floating beside vehicle, which we will bag. No sign of blood or some type of forced entry. Going to need a crane

for extraction."

No body in the vehicle. Chad closed his eyes for one second — relief and dread arriving in the same package, as they so often did in this town.

"Chief, I am going to head into town and speak to the real estate agent that we met with a few days ago," Chad said. "If Marina returned, that is the only person she knows here — unless she went back to the Ravencrest Mansion for some unknown reason."

"I will be here for the rest of the day, but most likely we will be staying here for a few days," Patterson said. "Let me know if you hear anything of interest from the agent. And check in at a local motel and text me where you're staying!"



Coastal Dreams Realty occupied a storefront on the square that was, like its proprietor, immaculate in a way that discouraged closer inspection — fresh flowers, straightened brochures, listings for properties that never seemed to change. Linda Rhodes sat behind her desk, perfectly composed, when the office door banged open and Chad Wellington came through it unannounced.

"The maid found Marina's note," he said. "She came to see you."

Linda didn't so much as straighten a paper. "Many people come to see me, Mr. Wellington. I am a real estate agent."

"Cut the act." Chad planted his hands on her desk, playing the bluff with everything he had. "I know about this town. About what really happens here."

Behind Linda, in the office window, her reflection caught the light — and for a fraction of a second, it *distorted*. The polished silhouette rippled, and something beneath it showed through: a suggestion of angles no human frame contained, gone before the eye could confirm it.

"Do you?" Linda said pleasantly. "Then you should know better than to threaten me, Mr. Wellington."

"The state police are involved now, Linda. Chief Patterson — a friend of mine — is running the investigation personally."

And there it was. For the first time since Chad had met her, Linda Rhodes' composure cracked — a hairline fracture, half a heartbeat long, but real. In a face like hers, it read like a scream.

Chad had spent a career across negotiating tables learning to price that exact micro-expression, and he priced this one on the way out the door: whatever was happening in Oceanview, it had a schedule. And Chief Patterson's helicopter had just landed in the middle of it.

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CHAPTER FIVE

WATCH YOURSELF, COUSIN

Afternoon in the study, and Charles was in full evangelist mode, his video-window self gesturing at futures only he could see.

"Think about it — we could revolutionize digital entertainment. I know adding a real personality to their AI agent system would seal the deal!"

The feed stuttered. Charles's image fragmented into blocks of color — and for one flickering moment, a different face assembled itself from the static. A face with a grin that predated the internet by decades.

"OH OH OHHHH!" Sam's voice crackled through the distortion. "Watch yourself, cousin!"

The feed snapped back to normal. Charles carried on mid-sentence, having noticed nothing, which was becoming the man's defining characteristic.

Movement in the study mirror caught Derek's eye — and for once, mercifully, it was a living person. Larry Leland stood reflected in the doorway, tools in hand. Derek watched the handyman's expression travel from casual to concerned as his eyes tracked something on the wall panels — the mansion's systems, activating in patterns that Larry, who knew every wire in this building like a family tree, clearly did not recognize. Larry caught Derek's eye in the mirror and gave a single deliberate shake of the head. Then, discreetly, he held up a circuit board he'd removed from somewhere — a green rectangle bearing distinctive markings that Derek had seen once before, in a dead man's journal. Jonathan Rhodes' markings.

"Let's stick to the basics for now," Derek said to Charles, receiving Larry's message loud and clear.

"I have a meeting I have to get to, so you're on your own the rest of today," Charles said. "Let's reconnect at five p.m., fifteen minutes before the presentation. I am counting on you, buddy."

Larry approached the desk as the call wound down, and spoke quietly. "Mr. K, something you should know. Found this connected to the main system. It's designed to record and transmit everything. Real sophisticated stuff... but not ours."

"Hang on, Larry."

Derek gave a wave to the camera and closed the connection with Charles. "See you later, alligator," he told the vanishing window, and slumped back into the chair with the full-body sigh of a man who now had to start working on his *other* presentation — the one for the Town Council, the one with an audience whose headsets he was trying very hard not to think about.

He turned to Larry and held out his hand. Larry passed him the board, and Derek examined it closely — the soldering, the strange elegance of the trace patterns, the markings.

"See what I mean, Mr. K?"

"Wow. This is early high tech, Larry." The concern settled visibly onto Derek's face. "There is no way Charles could have done that, which means we have another interested party in this place's tech. I want you to do a thorough inspection of every system in the places you are aware of and see if there are any more surprises. And Larry — mum's the word on this until I can figure out what is going on."

"10-4, Mr. K." Larry turned and exited, tools clinking, leaving Derek alone with the circuit board and its dead inventor's signature. Derek set it on the desk, next to the torn journal page, next to the note from the dumbwaiter — the study was accumulating exhibits

now, a little evidence table assembling itself around his keyboard — and he had the distinct sense that the case they were building had already chosen its detective, and hadn't asked.

Derek turned it over in his hands, mumbling to himself. "Just when I thought I was out... they pull me back in." The Pacino came out on reflex, gravel and grievance.

In the study mirror — unnoticed, and enjoying it — Robin Williams now stood, arms crossed, eyebrows at maximum altitude.

"If Pacino bites the big one, Junior, you will have to find another impression to hijack, 'cause he will go ballistic on you," Robin's reflection said, already three gears into the riff. "He *hates* impressions of him. I know — I worked with the guy."

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CHAPTER SIX

BEHIND DR. BLACKWOOD

In the library, Nancy had showered, dressed, and returned to her post with the focus of a woman who had officially reclassified this from *hobby* to *investigation*. The second tape was running. *GOVERNOR'S VISIT*. The footage was faded but legible: crowds filing into the old theater, every head crowned with one of the "experience enhancer" headsets, wires gleaming under the house lights. And there, in the background of nearly every shot, Jonathan Rhodes at his controls, making small adjustments, watching the crowd the way a conductor watches an orchestra.

"Fascinating technology."

Nancy jumped approximately one full foot. Smithers had appeared beside her, silent as a change in air pressure.

"Though some might say consciousness is not meant to be... shared," he continued, as though he had been part of the conversation all along.

"What do you mean by that?"

Smithers placed a tray on the table — a cup of tea and, she noted, a couple of rice crispy squares, because word traveled fast in this house. "Simply an observation, Miss Nancy. Though if you're interested in sharing, might I suggest checking behind the portrait of Dr. Blackwood?"

He exited as silently as he'd arrived, which Nancy was beginning to suspect was less a skill and more a commute.

She looked at the tray. Took a square — obviously — and crossed to the portrait of Dr. Blackwood, the old physician's painted

eyes supervising the library as they had for decades. She ran her fingers along the frame's edge and found what her fingers had somehow already known would be there: hinges. The portrait swung open like a door.

Behind it, a hidden panel. And inside: more VHS tapes, and documents — folders of them, yellowed and waiting.

Nancy stood there with a rice crispy square in one hand and a dead man's secrets in the other, and thought, not for the first time, that this house had a very particular idea of what constituted an afternoon snack.

She lifted the first folder out. Documents — carbon copies, typed, official-looking, the letterhead too faded to read in this light. Beneath them, more tapes, their labels in that same relentless handwriting. The house had been keeping this drawer for somebody. It had waited through a closure, a tragedy, four decades of dust — and then it had sent a butler with tea to point her at it. Nancy glanced up at Dr. Blackwood's painted face, swung open on its hinges, regarding the ceiling at an undignified angle.

"Sorry, Doctor," she said, and started reading.



Out at the lake, Officer Martinez had located the two witnesses whose morning activities had been called in by a tip, and was rapidly regretting it.

"We received a tip that you two were seen heading towards the lake early this morning," Martinez said, pen ready. "What time did you get here?"

"We got to the old dock around seven a.m. and did what we always do," Earl said, very calm, very polite. "Fish."

"Then the dock just took off!" Pete blurted, sounding like a man whose nervous system had not yet been debriefed. "Like something

was pulling it!"

"Biggest catfish you ever saw," Earl said. Then, after a beat, with the timing of a man who had spent seventy years perfecting the ominous trail-off: "Or maybe it wasn't a catfish at all..."

Martinez looked from one to the other, his pen unmoving, his notebook page as blank as his options. He had been trained to detect deception, and the frustrating thing — the thing he would not be putting in his report — was that neither of these men read as lying. They read as *editing*.

In the lake behind them, something large sent a slow ripple across the surface. Martinez didn't notice.

Earl and Pete did. They exchanged a look — the knowing kind, the kind two men share when they have both privately upgraded their relationship with a body of water.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

ALWAYS LEAVE THEM WANTING MORE

Early evening, and the State Police command center hummed with the low urgency of an investigation finding its shape — folding tables, laptops, coffee in cups that had given up on being warm. Chief Patterson stood before a monitor, reviewing footage recovered from Marina's phone.

Patterson had run missing persons cases for thirty years, and they had a grammar to them: timelines, gaps, the last person to see, the first person to lie. This one's grammar was broken. The timeline had a hole with scorched edges, and the technology kept flinching every time he got close to it.

The screen showed Marina entering Linda's office — timestamp in the corner, footsteps steady, a woman keeping an appointment. Then static — a violent burst of interference, the frame shredding into noise. When the image cleared, the camera had caught Linda's reflection in a window.

The reflection was wrong. Distorted. *Not human-like*. Patterson leaned in, and thirty years of professional skepticism leaned in with him, and neither of them could make the image be anything else.

"Chief, look at this frame." Martinez froze the video on the reflection. The image seemed to pulse on the screen with an energy that had no business surviving compression.

"Send this to forensics," Patterson said. "And get me everything you can on Linda Rhodes."

Martinez was making notes in a leather-bound notebook. "Rhodes? Her business card says—"

"I know what it says. Find out who she really is. Cross-reference every database — property records, tax files, birth certificates. Something tells me 'Linda Rhodes' hasn't always been her name."

Martinez studied the frozen image. "Chief, look at the timestamp. This was taken right before the phone records show her signal disappeared."

"And right before the power surge that knocked out half the town's security cameras. Get me the electrical grid reports from that night. Also, see if anyone has spotted Wellington driving around town."

Martinez nodded, adding more notes. Through the command center's window, lightning flashed across a perfectly clear sky, and nobody in the room looked up, because they were new here.



At Ravencrest, the great room had become a theater. Derek stood at its center conducting the remote presentation, holographic displays filling the space with slowly rotating data visualizations — architecture diagrams, performance curves, the respectable furniture of a corporate pitch. In the video conference window floated the Jacobson team: Thomas Jacobson, sixties, CEO, glasses and gravity; Sarah Chen, forties, Head of AI Development, watching everything twice; Michael Foster, thirties, Technical Director, laptop open like a shield.

"As you can see, our AI integration allows—"

Derek had rehearsed this pitch twice, which by his standards was extravagant preparation. He had the beats, the pauses, the little self-deprecating aside queued for minute four. He would get to use almost none of it.

The holographs *changed*.

Not glitched. Changed. The tidy corporate visuals dissolved and re-formed into things that had no place in any pitch deck: past performances on a stage that no longer existed, forgotten moments rendered in impossible fidelity, glimpses — brief, clinical, unmistakable — of consciousness transfer experiments. The great room filled with light and memory, the mansion opening its photo album for guests Derek had absolutely not intended to show it to.

Derek stood in the middle of it, holding a laser pointer that had never felt more decorative, running the executive calculus at panic speed: interrupt the display and admit he wasn't in control of it, or narrate along and pretend this was all on the storyboard. Fifteen years of corporate improv made the call for him. He kept his face in *scheduled-feature* mode and let the house finish its sentence.

Sarah Chen leaned forward, speaking quietly to Thomas. "That signature pattern... it's unlike anything in our development pipeline."

Michael Foster was typing frantically. "The processing speed alone would require quantum-level computing."

Thomas removed his glasses and studied the display with the intensity of a man recalculating his company's five-year plan in real time. "Remarkable."

The Jacobson team sat mesmerized, exchanging glances loaded with meaning and dollar signs, as the system demonstrated capabilities that made "cutting edge" sound quaint.

"This is extraordinary!" Charles burst in via video, lit up like a slot machine. "How are you—"

The systems snapped back to normal. Corporate diagrams. Performance curves. Respectable furniture.

Derek caught movement in the doorway: Larry, giving him a significant wide-eyed look that translated, roughly, to *that wasn't*

me, Mr. K.

"Just some prototype features," Derek said smoothly. "Not ready for implementation, but you know what they say... always leave them wanting more..." The nervous laugh he appended fooled no one, least of all himself.

Thomas turned to Sarah and said, almost inaudibly — but not quite inaudibly enough: "Whatever the cost... make this upgrade happen."

In the room's mirrors — plural, because the great room had never met a wall it didn't want to reflect — an audience had assembled. Deceased comedians, arrayed like critics on opening night, elbows on the glass, reviewing the living with the merciless affection the dead reserve for amateurs.

On the Charles feed, a large smile spread across Charles Weber's face as he pretended, very badly, not to have overheard Thomas's comment.

"I tell ya, this AI gets no respect!" Rodney's reflection barked, tugging his tie. "No respect at all!"

"Oh, grow up!" Joan Rivers' reflection fired back. "I've had software updates more exciting than this presentation!"

Derek, who could hear none of this and yet somehow felt the heckling on his skin, moved to close. "That concludes our demonstration, folks. I hope it has met your aspirational goals at Jacobson, and I will leave the next round of discussion to you and Charles. I appreciate your time, and hopefully being able to continue our collaboration to make Jacobson the number one investment fund in the world. Again, thank you — and I must end the feed, as I need to make use of the little boys' room."

He clicked the mouse, the window collapsed, and Derek leaned back in the chair and laughed at himself — at how *corporate* he still

was, that departing speech rolling out of him fully formed, instinct making like he was still employed there, still wearing the lanyard, still somebody's Q3.

"Sounds like you hit a home run, Master Kinison." Smithers, appearing as usual, set a tray on the side table. "I thought as a reward, you would enjoy another rice crispy square and a snifter of thirty-year-old port and a selection of some amazing cheeses."

"You are a mind reader as well, Smithers. And I am afraid it was not just a home run — it was a grand slam in the bottom of the ninth in game seven of the World Series, and it travelled out of the ballpark." Derek looked at the port, the cheese, the square. "And that scares me!"



CHAPTER EIGHT

SHE WAS CHOSEN

The town general store smelled like every general store in America — floor wax, cardboard, and time — and carried the same inventory it had carried since the Carter administration, on the theory that if the town ever needed anything new, it would say so. Nancy moved down the aisles checking items off a handwritten list: batteries, flashlights, women's products, and an old-style tape recorder, because some investigations called for equipment that couldn't be remotely wiped.

The elderly cashier eyed the pile as she rang it up. "Planning some late-night reading, Mrs. Hammond?"

"Just stocking up. Never know when the power might go out in these old houses."

It was then that Nancy noticed the cashier's red baseball cap. It read: MAKE OCEANVIEW GREAT AGAIN. Nancy suppressed most of a smirk — most of it — as the cashier bagged her purchases with a smile that suggested the cap was doing exactly the work its owner intended.

Through the store's front window, movement caught her eye: Linda Rhodes, exiting her office across the street, checking her watch with an urgency that Linda Rhodes did not do. Linda Rhodes glided. Linda Rhodes arrived and departed like weather. Linda Rhodes did not *hurry* — and yet there she was, hurrying, heels striking the sidewalk in a rhythm that belonged to someone with a deadline.

Nancy paid, stepped out into the square, and watched Linda beeline toward the old church. The building's Gothic architecture

loomed against the afternoon sky, its stained glass windows catching the light like watchful eyes — which, in this town, was not necessarily a figure of speech.

A moment's hesitation — the last exit before the toll, some sensible interior voice noted, the voice that had also advised against buying a haunted mansion and had been overruled on that occasion too. Then Nancy stashed her bags in the Tesla and followed.

As she crossed toward the church, thunder rumbled overhead. The sky was cloudless. The thunder didn't care.

She found her spot in the shadows of an ancient oak beside an ornate stained glass window that stood partially open, and crouched there, watching silhouettes gather in the room beyond — council members, arriving one by one, assembling through the colored glass like dark birds settling onto a wire.

"The police involvement is unfortunate," a council member's voice drifted out.

"The transformation cannot be stopped now." Linda's voice, unmistakable. "She was chosen."

"And the husband?"

"He knows too much. He'll need to be... processed."

Nancy's breath went shallow. And then, through the stained glass, she watched the silhouettes *shift* — the human outlines stretching, rearranging, becoming shapes that her brain refused to file under any existing category. Inhuman forms, backlit in fragments of colored light.

She rubbed her eyes, hard, disbelief performing its one trick.

When she looked back, the silhouettes were people again. Just people, in a church, in the afternoon.

But Nancy Hammond knew what she had seen.

She stayed in the oak's shadow for another minute, pulse loud in her ears, cataloguing it the way she'd learned to catalogue everything in this town: not *what was that* but *where does it fit*. The council. The church. *She was chosen*. The phrases arranged themselves alongside the headsets on the VHS tapes and the hidden panel behind Dr. Blackwood, and the arrangement had a shape now. She didn't like the shape.

She walked back to the Tesla at exactly the speed of a woman not fleeing anything, and did not exhale properly until the doors locked.



Night at the lake, and the state police search lights swept the water in long white blades. Earl and Pete sat in their lawn chairs beside the shortened dock, beers in hand, watching the operation with the settled air of season-ticket holders.

"You think they'll find her?" Pete asked.

"Some things aren't meant to be found, Pete."

"Like Old Moses?"

"Old Moses is just a fish." Earl took a pull of his beer and looked out at the black water, at the searchlights skating across its surface and illuminating exactly nothing. "What lives in this lake... that's something else entirely."

Beneath the surface, something massive moved. The wave it pushed ahead of itself rolled in and rocked the remaining dock section, gently, like a knock on a door from the wrong side.



CHAPTER NINE

WE NEED TO TALK. — AISAM

The study at night had a different personality — the Victorian shadows deeper, the monitor glow colder. Derek sat reviewing the presentation footage he'd given to the Jacobson team and Charles, scrubbing back and forth through the recording, trying to figure out what, exactly, had happened in his great room that evening.

The images made it worse, not better. Frame by frame, the discrepancies stacked up — moments where the AI had operated entirely independently, revealing far more than Derek's canned presentation had ever contained. He hadn't shown them the past performances. He hadn't shown them the experiments. The system had made an editorial decision, and the editor wasn't him.

Every screen went dark.

All except one.

Text appeared, white on black:

We need to talk. — AISAM

Derek stared at it. "Sam? Or whatever you are?"

The screens flickered back to life — and now they showed something new. Security footage. Charles Weber's old office, the one Derek knew down to the carpet stains, and Charles in it, talking with Barry, the head IT guy. On the screen-within-the-screen, the two of them were reviewing Derek's presentation in slow motion. Then the footage cut to a closeup: Barry's terminal, and on it, the unmistakable anatomy of an intrusion attempt. Barry was trying to hack the mansion's IP address.

"The IP originated from somewhere near the coast, but it's unlike anything I've seen," Barry was saying on the recording. "The encryption's decades ahead of current tech. It looks like the IP packet has its own encryption system wrapping the IP."

"Find a way in." Charles's voice, stripped of all its buddy-buddy warmth, was something colder and hungrier. "Whatever's powering their presentation system... I want it. If you need to hire the best hacker person you can, to help you... cost is not an issue! I want an update tomorrow."

On the footage, Barry typed frantically — then frowned. "Sir, something's pushing back. It's like the system knows we're—"

Barry's screen flooded, edge to edge, with Sam's laughing face.

"He's looking for things he shouldn't find," AISAM said through the study's speakers, the voice warm and sharp at once. "OH OH OHHHH! And trust me, kid — some things should stay buried."

The screens went dark again, all of them this time, and Derek sat in the Victorian gloom with his heart doing something arrhythmic and his mind doing something worse. The house hadn't just shown him a security feed. It had shown him a *choice* of security feed — curated, timestamped, delivered with commentary. Charles was digging. Someone else had already planted a bug. And the thing in the walls that sounded exactly like his dead cousin had opinions about both.

"Some things should stay buried," Derek repeated to the empty room. He wished the sentence had sounded, even slightly, like it was about the past.



CHAPTER TEN

OFF THE CLOCK

Nancy burst into the mansion library still breathless from the church, from the drive, from the shapes behind the stained glass. She found Derek at the table, Rhodes' journal open in front of him, the books and the map spread out exactly where she'd left them.

"Derek, you won't believe—"

Her phone rang. The screen read: STATE POLICE — CHIEF'S OFFICE.

"Mrs. Hammond?" The voice was gravel wrapped in courtesy. "I got your number from the Town Council's office. My name is Chief Patterson with the State Police department. We are trying to locate the whereabouts of a Mrs. Marina St. Clair and Mr. Chad Wellington. Are they by chance there, visiting you?"

Nancy grabbed for her composure with both hands. "I am very sorry, Chief, but they are not here, and I have not seen them since they left here a few days ago."

"Well, if they should turn up there, please ask Mr. Wellington to contact me ASAP. He has my number."

"Certainly. I hope they're alright."

"Thank you for your cooperation."

The line went dead. Nancy stood holding the phone, aware of Derek watching her, aware of the journal open on the table, aware that the day's discoveries were now arriving faster than she could shelve them. She turned back to Derek with a puzzled and concerned look on her face — and, underneath it, the electric flicker of a woman whose evening had just acquired a second act.

"Who was that?" Derek asked.

"State Police. You'll never guess who's missing." The concern was shifting into a grin and raised eyebrows despite her best efforts.

"Hang on — you have to tell me first what 'I won't believe' is, before you get to ask me to make a guess."

Nancy took a breath, regaining her composure by degrees. "When I was in town getting a few items, I spotted Linda in town. So, feeling a bit adventurous, I decided to tail her."

Derek's expression shifted from playful to concerned in the space of a syllable. "Nancy, that was incredibly dangerous. We don't know what Linda's capable of." He moved closer. "When Charles visited, I saw something in the mansion's security logs... Linda was accessing areas that shouldn't exist."

"That's exactly why I followed her. Derek, something's happening in this town beyond supposed ghost-comedian urban legends and incredible AI systems."

"What, have you become Jessica Fletcher — the hot perky version with a" — and by now the growl needed no introduction, arriving like a guest with his own key — "*GREAT ASS?*"

"Very funny. But I swear that when I was peering in through the church's stained glass window, Linda and another council person changed their appearance into something strange."

"OK, you been sipping a little wine at the diner in town, Ms. Hammond?"

"Derek, I am serious. I know it sounds bonkers, but for a split second, they *changed*."

"What do you mean, a split second?"

"I could not believe what I saw, so I rubbed my eyes to make sure I wasn't imagining it."

"And when you looked again, they were still transformed?"

"Well, no. They appeared normal again. But I know, Derek — I was not hallucinating or seeing things. I am sure there is something supernatural going on with her!"

Derek walked over and pulled Nancy into a hug. Not a hug that suggested he didn't believe her. A hug that said: *it's okay, I'm here*. There is a difference, and after ten years of marriage, both parties can grade the distinction blind.

"And that was not all," Nancy said into his shoulder. "I think I overheard them mention something about Chad and Marina. I was a little too far away to hear it clearly, but I am sure I heard Linda say, 'The transformation cannot be stopped now. She was chosen.'"

Derek's phone chimed. He read the text over the top of Nancy's head:

Mr. Kinison, due to a police matter in town, your presentation has been postponed for one more week. Very sorry for the inconvenience. Will be in touch.

"Never guess who just texted me," Derek said.

Nancy pushed him back to arm's length, a playful grin breaking through everything else. "Very funny, Mr. Kinison."

"Linda Rhodes just texted me. The presentation is postponed another week due to a police matter in town."

"I knew it, Derek. I just *knew* it. Something very fishy is going on in this town — this mansion, for that matter. I need to show you what I found behind the painting."

"Since I don't need to do any rehearsing, let's go and chill. I am sure we are both tired, and I think a nice long bath after a rice crispy is what the doctor ordered for us."

"That actually sounds great. But I want to show you this stuff tomorrow. Oh — how did the presentation go with Charles?"

"We can discuss that as well tomorrow. We are officially off the clock, my perfect-butt girl." Derek punctuated the title with a playful pat on said asset as they headed for the library door. "Oh — what was the phone call about, that you wanted me to guess?"

"That was the State Police asking me if Chad and Marina were visiting us." Nancy flipped off the light. "Seems they are both missing."

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

ROOM AT THE OCEANVIEW

The Oceanview Motel office glowed its usual jaundiced yellow against the evening, the VACANCY sign humming its one-word soliloquy at the empty road. Behind the desk, Mr. Crane presided over the register like a man who had been issued with the building — which, given what Chad now suspected about this town, was not a hypothesis he was prepared to rule out.

"Looks like I need the cabin again, Mr. Crane. I trust it's available?"

"Yes, it is. How many nights will you be staying?"

"To be honest, I am not sure. At least one, so let's start there." Chad glanced at the dark road outside. "Also, are there any food places that deliver?"

"Well, the diner is closed, but old Mrs. Hawksbill will rustle you up a fine meal for ten dollars cash, and for another ten, her son Melvin will deliver it. Want me to place a dinner order for you, Mr. Wellington?"

"Great. And here is a little something for you." Chad slid a hundred-dollar bill across the desk.

Mr. Crane looked at it with genuine delight. "Gee whiz, Mr. Wellington, that is mighty generous of you. Is Mrs. Wellington going to be joining you? I can order two dinners, same delivery fee."

"No. Solo tonight." Chad picked up the cabin key. "Although you may have a police officer or two wanting a room tonight."

"Ya, I heard there is some woman missing." Mr. Crane said it the way other men discussed the weather. "Been a long time since we

had one of those situations here."

Chad looked at Mr. Crane — at the mild eyes, the unbothered face, the phrase *one of those situations* hanging in the air like a fishhook — smiled, grabbed his key, and left the office.

Outside, the motel sign buzzed against the dark, and Chad stood under it for a moment doing the math. *Been a long time since we had one of those situations here.* Which meant there had been others. Which meant somewhere in this town there was a ledger of *those situations*, and Marina was now an entry in it — and Chad Wellington III, who had bought his way into or out of every room he'd ever entered, was beginning to understand that this town ran on a currency he didn't hold.



Back at Ravencrest, through the library's tall windows, lightning flashed against a clear night sky. And in every mirror in the room, they had gathered — the deceased comedians, arranged like a ghostly audience waiting for a show that hadn't been announced yet.

George Carlin's reflection leaned toward the glass, conversational as ever, hands doing that precise surgical thing they always did when he was about to take a word apart to show you the wiring inside.

"Ever notice how people don't really disappear? They just stop being where we expect them to be."

The mirrors held the thought a moment longer. Then the lightning pulsed again, and the audience was gone, and the library was just a library — books, dust, and a portrait hanging very slightly ajar.



In the Town Council chamber, Linda stood before the assembled members, their faces hidden in shadow, the room lit like a painting nobody would hang in a home.

"The state police presence forces us to postpone the performance," Linda said.

"The timing is unfortunate," a council member replied from the dark. "The energies are nearly aligned."

Linda's voice carried through the chamber with none of the realtor's warmth. That voice was a listing; this one was the fine print. "We have contained the Wellington woman. Her husband will follow."

"And the Kinisons?"

"They are... different." A pause, and something in Linda's voice that might have been respect, or might have been appetite. "The mansion has chosen them."

Thunder crashed directly overhead. The chamber's ancient chandelier swayed, crystals ticking against each other in the dark, keeping time for a meeting that had never once appeared in any minutes.



In the mansion's great room, Derek — bathrobe, bare feet, port-adjacent — had discovered another cache of Rhodes' hidden journal entries, these about the headsets. The pages had been tucked where hidden pages in this house always seemed to be tucked: exactly where he'd think to look at exactly the moment he thought to look there, a filing system whose librarian preferred to remain anonymous. Nancy sat curled nearby, watching him read aloud.

"The consciousness transfer was successful," Derek read, "but something else came through. Something ancient. Something that was waiting..."

The pipe organ — which had been uncharacteristically quiet the past couple of days, a silence they had both noticed and neither had trusted — suddenly began to play. Bach's Toccata in D Minor thundered through the great room, every gothic horror movie's opening number, performed live and unattended.

Derek and Nancy looked at each other with wide eyes and raised eyebrows and grabbed each other's hand.

Neither of them moved. The Toccata rolled through the great room, filling the vaulted dark, rattling the port glass on its tray — the mansion's entire acoustic architecture apparently having been designed, all along, for exactly this.

Behind them, in a mirror neither was facing, the reflection told the rest of the story: Sam, in a tuxedo and a black beret, arms sweeping grandly through the air, conducting the empty organ with the full-bodied commitment of a man who had waited thirty-three years for this particular gig. He brought the final chord home with both arms, held it, held it — and released it into the night like a dove.



At the State Police command center, the Toccata's final phrases seemed to bleed impossibly into the room's ambient hum as Chief Patterson reviewed the final footage from Marina's phone, freshly delivered from the forensic department.

The screen showed Marina approaching the council building. Then the image distorted — violently, the frame tearing itself apart in bursts of static.

And through the static, as the last organ chord decayed somewhere in the night, Marina's scream:

"No, please — NOOOOOOO!"

When the image cleared, the camera lay on the ground, recording an empty sidewalk. Patient. Indifferent. Empty.

Not quite empty. At the very edge of what the fallen lens could see, across the street and half out of view, a pair of gloved hands adjusted a small instrument — unhurried, methodical, the motions of someone finishing a measurement rather than starting one. The hands lowered the instrument. A moment later the sidewalk was exactly as advertised.

Patterson watched the footage twice more. Then he sat down in the nearest folding chair, in the manner of a man setting something heavy down carefully, and said nothing at all — which, for anyone who knew Chief Patterson, was the loudest thing he'd done all day.



EPILOGUE: TO OLD MOSES

Night on Crescent Lake. The state police had packed their searchlights off to wherever searchlights sleep, and the lake had its dark back.

Earl and Pete sat at the end of their truncated dock — the amputation still raw-edged and pale where the wood had torn — fishing with regular hooks this time, a gas lantern burning behind them and a cooler of beer between them. There was an unspoken agreement in effect regarding bait: nothing from Betty's special menu. Some lessons only need teaching once. Out over the water, lightning illuminated the lake in strange pulses — not flashes, *pulses*, rhythmic, like something breathing light.

"I know I have only been in this town a few years, Earl," Pete said, "but I have to say, this is the weirdest stuff I have ever seen."

"Well, Pete, this is nothing." Earl settled deeper into his chair. "This town used to be the hottest destination spot in the country, back when the Laugh Asylum was open. Famous people from all over came here. Money flowed, and people in this town got rich. Then the tragedy and death of Mr. Rhodes, and then Mr. Kinison. Town died after that." He looked out at the pulsing dark. "Kinda feels like it may be coming back to life again!"

Beneath the surface, something massive moved — a slow displacement of water that sent a wave rolling in to rock both their chairs. Neither man seemed surprised. Surprise, at this point, would have been rude.

Earl raised his beer. "To Old Moses."

"To Old Moses."

In the lake's black mirror of a surface, the reflection that toasted back at them wasn't either of theirs. Sam — spectral, serene, and wearing a fishing hat festooned with lures — raised a ghostly beer of his own.

"OH OH OHHHH!" Sam's reflection crowed across the water. "Now *that's* what I call a fish story!"

The surface broke. Something began to rise — water sheeting off a shape the darkness declined to describe, the lantern light reaching out toward it and then, apparently, thinking better of the whole thing.

And the night, showing better judgment than anyone in it, cut to black before we could see what emerged.

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Here's the thing about "missing," folks. A car can be missing. A woman can be missing. A whole town can go missing for forty years and nobody sends a search party. But nothing in Oceanview is ever really gone — it's just waiting in the wings for its cue. And OH OH OHHHH... the orchestra's warming up.

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THE MISSING PERSONS FILE

Recovered fragment — State Police Incident Report, Case #26-0410

SUBJECT: St. Clair, Marina — last confirmed sighting, Coastal Dreams Realty office.

VEHICLE: Range Rover, recovered Crescent Lake. Interior sealed. No occupant. No sign of forced entry. Handbag recovered floating adjacent. Crane extraction pending.

ANOMALIES (UNRESOLVED): Power surge disabling municipal security cameras coincident with subject's last phone signal. Photographic distortion, subject's phone (forensics: "no known compression artifact matches"). Reflection anomaly, frame 4471 — flagged, unexplained.

WITNESS STATEMENTS: Two local men report dock section "pulled away" by unidentified force. Statement includes references to "Old Moses." Reliability: pending.

NOTE (Chief Patterson, handwritten): *Find out who Linda Rhodes really is.*

STATUS: MISSING



END OF BOOK 6

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca